

face and hard of heart." In order to carry out his mission to the end he needed to have fulfilled toward him what his name Ezekiel meant, namely, "God Strengthens." At the time, they might not view or appreciate him as a prophet of Jehovah. But whether they heard him as such or refrained from hearing and paying attention to him, the occasion was to come when these rebellious people would "know also that a prophet himself happened to be in the midst of them." Jehovah would confirm him as a prophet before them by causing what Ezekiel prophesied to come true. (Ezekiel 2:3-5) The expectation of this would be a comfort and strength to Ezekiel, not to be discouraged because of the way he was being considered and treated at the moment.

²³ Likewise it was a trying mission upon which the modern Ezekiel class was sent, to religious people of the same type as those in Ezekiel's day. But regardless of how Christendom views or regards this group of anointed witnesses of Jehovah, the time must come, and that shortly, when those making up Christendom will know that really a "prophet" of Jehovah was among them.

²⁴ Would we today like to tell Jehovah's message among things that prick us and among scorpions? It would take great courage and trust in the One who sent us to do so. Into such a situation Ezekiel was sent, according to the words that Jehovah further said to him: "And you, O son of man, do not be afraid of them; and of their words do not be afraid, because there are obstinate ones and things pricking you and it is among scorpions that you are dwelling. Of their words do not you be afraid, and at their faces do not you be struck with terror, for they are a rebellious house. And you must speak my words to them, regardless of whether they hear or they refrain, for they are

³³ Why is the mission of the modern-day Ezekiel class likewise a trying one, but, too, what must Christendom also come to know?

³⁴ Ezekiel was told to speak God's word fearlessly despite what about the rebellious house of Israel, and why has the anointed remnant of Jehovah's witnesses likewise had to speak fearlessly?

a case of rebellion." (Ezekiel 2:6, 7) Since the year 1919 C.E. the anointed remnant of Jehovah's witnesses have found it to be just like that as they have spoken fearlessly the word of Jehovah in the midst of Christendom.

"The religious condition today in Christendom bears witness to the fact that, rebelliously, she has not listened to the word from Jehovah's Holy Scriptures that has been spoken to her by every means of communication, by house-to-house calls with the printed page, by recordings played on portable phonographs, by the loudspeakers of sound cars, by direct public lectures, by radio networks and by television. Regardless of Christendom's indifference or even rebelliousness, the anointed witnesses of Jehovah have done just as He told Ezekiel to do, saying: "And you, O son of man, hear what I am speaking to you. Do not become rebellious like the rebellious house. Open your mouth and eat what I am giving you."—Ezekiel 2:8.

"What was Ezekiel given to eat? His written account tells us: "And I began to see, and, look! there was a hand thrust out to me, and, look! in it there was the roll of a book. And he gradually spread it out before me, and it was written upon in front and on the back; and there were written in it dirges and moaning and wailing." (Ezekiel 2:9, 10) From what was written on the scroll Ezekiel learned the content of the message that he was to deliver to the rebellious house of Israel in the name of Jehovah.

"As no space was wasted on the scroll, but it was written upon on both sides, front and back, it was to be a full message that Ezekiel proclaimed, it was to contain a great deal of gloomy dirges, moaning and wailing. It was to be no pleasant message, and it would

35. Christendom's condition today shows that she has responded in what way to Jehovah's word presented by every means of communication, and so in what way should Christendom not be imitated?

36. What was Ezekiel given to eat, and what did it contain, for his information?

37. How was the fullness of the message to be delivered portrayed, and why was the kind of message the proper one to be delivered, both by Ezekiel and by Jehovah's witnesses of today?